

Ebbing

Memory retreats on the ebb
Words have been drawn away, some of them
Like *frigate*, and *sluggish*
And that thing, the ... you know... you know?
You do, or you don't
But we get by with what remains
And later we remember
And it returns with the flow.

Sound retreats on the ebb
Consonants have been stolen away, some of them
Syllables are absurdly obfuscated
Pardon and *what* chase each remark
Conversations eddy round mis-hearings
But we get by with subtitles
And later we remember to turn up the volume
And it returns with the flow

Time retreats on the ebb
Years have been dragged away, some of them
Exposing an old tyre, a sea-weeded skeleton
Bad decisions, glistening and salty in the wind
We ache for recision
But we get by with tenderness
And later we forget
As years return with the flow.

You retreat on the ebb
You have been wafted away, parts of you
The parts that make sense, and remember me
And beyond the featureless mudflats
The sea is a line on the horizon, seething
But we get by with fragments
And together we wait
For the return of the flow.

Chris Adie